whistles to pass by starboard, five for a warning.

The same terms in European languages, meanwhile, often have fraught political valences conditioned by historical context. French used *dénonciateur* throughout much of the twentieth century, until the word's WWII-era association with being a "denouncer" or "informant" for the Germans led to a preference for *lanceur d'alerte* ("one who launches a warning"). German, a language that has struggled with its culture's Nazi and Stasi past, evolved beyond its own *Denunziant* and *Informant* to settle on the unsatisfactory *Hinweisgeber* (a "hint- or tip-giver"), *Enthueller* ("revealer"), *Skandalaufdecker* ("scandal-uncoverer"), and even the pointedly political *ethische Dissidenten* ("ethical dissident"). German uses few of these words online, however; with respect to today's Internet-based disclosures, it has simply borrowed the noun *Whistleblower* and the verb *leaken*. The languages of regimes like Russia and China, for their part, employ terms that bear the pejorative sense of "snitch" and "traitor." It would take the existence of a strong free press in those societies to imbue those words with a more positive coloration, or to coin new ones that would frame disclosure not as a betrayal but as an honorable duty.

Ultimately, every language, including English, demonstrates its culture's relationship to power by how it chooses to define the act of disclosure. Even the nautically derived English words that seem neutral and benign frame the act from the perspective of the institution that perceives itself wronged, not of the public that the institution has failed. When an institution decries "a leak," it is implying that the "leaker" damaged or sabotaged something.

Today, "leaking" and "whistleblowing" are often treated as interchangeable. But to my mind, the term "leaking" should be used differently than it commonly is. It should be used to describe acts of disclosure done not out of public interest but out of self-interest, or in pursuit of institutional or political aims. To be more precise, I understand a leak as something closer to a "plant," or an incidence of "propaganda-seeding": the selective release of protected information in order to sway popular opinion or affect the course of decision making. It is rare for even a day to go by in which some "unnamed" or "anonymous" senior government official does not leak, by way of a hint or tip to a journalist, some classified item that advances their own agenda or the efforts of their agency or party.

This dynamic is perhaps most brazenly exemplified by a 2013 incident in which IC officials, likely seeking to inflate the threat of terrorism and deflect criticism of mass surveillance, leaked to a few news websites extraordinarily detailed accounts of a conference call between al-Qaeda leader Ayman al-